



Biting attack

Vampire bats exist in real life, and not just in horror movies. They live in Mexico, Central America, and South America, where they feast on the blood of mammals and birds. When a vampire bat tracks down its prey, it first uses its razor-sharp incisor teeth to bite into the animal's skin. Then the bat drinks its fill by lapping up the blood that flows from the wound.



Isopod's segmented body hides its legs and claws

Double trouble

Fish cannot groom themselves, which makes them easy targets for bloodsucking parasites. This host fish is being attacked by two isopods, which are sea crustaceans related to woodlice. Using their claws, the isopods have firmly latched on to the fish's head and are feeding on blood from the soft flesh near its gills.

Blood-thirsty bird

The sharp-beaked ground finch of the Galápagos Islands has a rare feeding habit among birds—it drinks the blood of living animals. This finch attacks boobies and other large sea birds, perching on their backs while it feeds. This behavior has earned the bird the nickname “vampire finch,” even though it eats mainly insects and seeds.



Lingering leech

This pike has an uninvited passenger—a fish leech, which uses its suckers to cling on to its host while feeding on its blood. Fish leeches find a host by resting in gravel or mud and stretching upward like plant stems. If a fish passes by, the leech quickly swims toward it and grabs hold with its biting jaws.

Sucker surrounds mouth at narrow end of body

Massive meal

Female sheep ticks have abdomens that stretch like balloons as they feed on blood. Adult females feed just once, taking a week or more to complete their meal. The tick's body weight increases by up to 50 times, and it can be as large as a grape. Once full, the tick drops off to lay its eggs on the ground.

Sheep tick before feeding



Sheep tick after feeding



Finch pecks at base of tail feathers, making blood flow

